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Book of Branch Office Rules

DISCLAIMER: *This booklet has been prepared strictly from an examination point of view. While every effort has been made to ensure accuracy and the inclusion of recent changes, amendments, and updates to the relevant Acts, Rules, and Regulations, this document is intended as a study aid only. Readers and students are strongly recommended to refer to official government sources or gazettes for the most reliable and authoritative information.*

Book of Branch Office Rules

Rule 5. Notice of Hours of Business

A notice of hours of business in **Form M-6(c)** will be supplied to each Branch Office (BO) by the Sub-Divisional Inspector (SDI). This notice must be pasted on a notice board and hung up prominently in the office to ensure it is visible to the public.

Rule 7. Village Sorting Lists, Route Lists, and Beat Maps

- **Village Sorting List (M-52):** This list displays the names of the villages served by each Assistant Branch Postmaster (ABPM), arranged in alphabetical order. It also indicates which villages have letter boxes and which of those are provided with changeable plates.
- **Route List (M-53) & Beat Map:** The route list is accompanied by a map of the beat. It details:
 - The route to be followed by the ABPM.
 - The days fixed for departure from and return to the Post Office.
 - The specific day each village must be visited.
 - The villages where the ABPM is allowed to halt.
- **Display:** The village sorting list, copies of route lists, and beat maps must be hung up in the post office.

Rule 8. Due Mail and Sorting Lists

A due mail and sorting list will be supplied to:

1. Every Branch Office in direct communication with the Railway Mail Service (R.M.S.) by the Superintendent R.M.S. concerned.

2. Every other Branch Office which acts as a transit or sorting office, by the Superintendent of Post Offices.
- **Due Mail List:** Shows the bag(s) to be received or dispatched to each office or section and specifies when bags must be accompanied by mail lists.
 - **Sorting List:** Details the articles to be sent in each bag by the Branch Office.

Chapter 2: Delivery and Staff Supervision

Rule 9. Supervision of Delivery Staff

The Branch Postmaster (BPM) supervises staff using the following records:

Record Name	Form No.	Description and Usage
Postman Book	MS-27	The book in which the Postman enters details of articles and e-Money Orders (eMO) received from the BPM.
Village Postman Register	MS-85	A register used by the Postman to enter article details and eMOs received from the BPM.
Village Postman Visit Book	MS-86	A visit book where the Village Postman enters the names of villages visited or to be visited. Red Ink (by BPM): Indicates villages that must be visited on that specific trip. Black Ink (by BPM): Indicates villages to be visited regularly.

Note: The weight of postal articles (including parcels) to be carried by a village postman or extra-departmental delivery agent must not exceed **10 kg**.

Chapter 3: Security, Cash, and Equipment

Rule 11. Custody of Cash

It is not mandatory to supply a safe to every extra-departmental branch office. A safe may be provided at the discretion of the Superintendent of Post Offices based on a report and recommendation supported by the S.D.I..

Rule 19. Stamps and Seals

Every Branch Office is supplied with a seal and the following stamps:

1. A combined name and date stamp of rectangular shape.
2. A postage-due stamp.
3. A number slip name-stamp (unless the BO does not do independent registration work).
- **Hour Type:** Branch offices dispatching mails in one direction more than **once a day** will be supplied with date-stamps containing hour type.
- **Usage:** The date stamp must be impressed on every communication addressed by the BPM to the Superintendent or S.D.I., in addition to other required stamps.

Rule 20. Book of Postmarks (MS-18)

A Book of Postmarks in **Form MS-18** must be maintained in every Branch Office.

- **Daily Procedure:** Impressions of all stamps holding date/movable type and the seal (if containing movable type) must be taken daily before use.

- **Verification:** The BPM must ensure impressions are distinct and clear, initialing the book every day after all impressions are taken.

Chapter 4: Records and Preservation

Rule 21. Preservation of Books and Forms

Records must be preserved for specific periods:

- **3 Years:** BO Account (PA-6) and BO Journal (PA-5).
- **2 Years:** Book of Receipt (MS-87(a)), registered lists, parcel lists, and mail lists.
- **Disposal:** Postman's book of receipt (MS-87), Book of Postmarks (MS-18), and Registered Journal (RP-51) should be destroyed by **shredding** in the BPM's presence to prevent reuse.

Rule 22. Book of Receipts [MS-87(a)]

This form is used to issue receipts to:

- Senders of insured or V.P. articles (letter or parcel mail).
- Remitters of Money Orders.
- P.L.I. policyholders for premium payments.
- Payers of telegraph charges realized in cash.

Each receipt bears a printed serial number, which is assigned to the article or money order.

Rule 36. Error Book (MS-2)

The Error Book (MS-2) is a permanent record of all irregularities, whether serious or petty.

- **Scope:** Includes irregularities committed by office staff or noticed from other offices/sections (e.g., mis-sending or misdirection of articles).

Rule 37-A. Suggestion/Complaint Book (MS-94)

- All Branch Post Offices must maintain a Complaint/Suggestion Book (**MS-94**).
- **Access:** It must be kept in a conspicuous place, easily accessible to the public without them having to ask for it.
- **Format:** The public can record complaints or suggestions in duplicate using a carbonic process.

Rule 42. Post Office Order Book (MS-8)

- **Purpose:** Used by inspecting officers to record remarks and orders.
- **Responsibility:** The BPM is personally responsible for promptly taking action on these remarks.
- **Integrity:** Each book contains **200 serially numbered pages**. Willful removal of a page is a serious offense liable for removal from service.
- **Status:** It is a permanent record and may not be destroyed without the Superintendent's special permission.

Rule 44. Branch Office Circulars

Circulars issued by Heads of Circles in regional languages must be supplied to all branch offices. These circulars are to be destroyed after **3 years** from the month of April following the close of the official year in which they were issued.

Chapter 5: Returns and Reports

Rule 45. Half-Yearly Enumeration Returns (MS-6)

- **Timing:** Conducted in the **second week of February** and **August** each year (**8th to the 21st**, inclusive).
- **Submission:** A copy of the return must be forwarded to the Account Office by the mail of the **15th**.
- **Data Collected:** Counts of ordinary unregistered letters, unregistered parcels delivered by postmen/village postmen/agents, and window delivery. Service articles must be counted separately.

Rule 46. Yearly Village Returns (MS-88)

- **Timing:** Maintained during the **first 14 days of March** each year (**1st to 14th**, inclusive).
- **Scope:** Records all articles (including money orders) received daily for delivery in each village.
- **Submission:** Totaled, signed by the BPM, and forwarded to the ASPOs/SDI on the **15th** of the month.

Rule 50. Leave Applications

Applications for leave by an extra-departmental BPM must be prepared in **Form App-45** in **4 copies** and submitted to the ASPOs/SDI. These are preserved for **3 years** after the BPM's service ends.

Chapter 6: Mail Handling and Sorting

Rule 53. Bags Received with Signs of Tampering

If a bag is found with missing cash/articles or signs of tampering:

1. Report immediately to the Superintendent and the dispatching office/section.
2. Preserve the bag and label (without detaching the seal/cord). Mark them with initials and the date stamp.
3. Record the irregularity in the Error Book.

Rule 59. Clearance of Letter-Boxes

- Clearance must occur at hours fixed by the ASPOs/SDI.
- **Paid Articles:** Those intended for delivery from the branch office itself should be delivered immediately.
- **Sorting:** All other articles are sorted according to the sorting list or set aside for dispatch to the Account Office.
- **Stamping:** Unregistered articles received in sorting for dispatch must **not** be stamped by the Branch Office.
- **Invalid Stamps:** Non-Indian postage stamps cannot be accepted and should not be defaced.

Rule 62. Unpaid and Insecure Articles

- **Action:** Open or insecure inland articles found in the letter-box or sorting must be securely closed.
- **Taxing:** Stamp with "Postage Due" if unpaid/insufficiently paid. Note the amount due before forwarding.

- **Accounting:** Do **not** credit the unpaid postage amount in the BO Account or Journal (PA-5).

Rule 64. Check Slips (MS-10)

A check slip is a label tied to the top of labeled bundles.

- **Pink:** Ordinary Station Paid and Unpaid Bundle.
- **White:** Ordinary Sorting Bundle (used for both Express and Deferred).
 - *Note:* Two diagonal blue lines indicate an Express bundle.
- **Blue (with "Air Mail"):** Foreign air mail bundles.

Rule 65. Labelled Bundles

Labeled bundles are defined as follows:

- **Station Bundle:** Contains unregistered articles for a particular station. Prepared when articles number **15** or more.
- **Sorting Bundle:** Contains unregistered articles for many stations.
- **Territorial Bundle:** A sorting bundle prepared for a specific state or tract of country. Prepared when articles number **25** or more.
- **Express Bundle:** Requires immediate sorting upon receipt.
- **Deferred Bundle:** Can be disposed of later.

Rule 66. Delivery of Unregistered Articles

- **Stamping:** Unregistered articles received for delivery must be date-stamped on the **back** (except postcards, which are stamped on the address side).
- **Redirection:** If given to a village postman/agent for delivery outside the town/village, they must be stamped again.

- **Postage Due:** Amounts due on unpaid articles must be entered in the BO Journal (PA-5).
- **Foreign Post:** An article received by foreign post must **never** be taxed with postage by the branch office.

Rule 67. Postage Taxing at Branch Office

- The BPM must properly tax all unpaid/insufficiently paid unregistered articles posted at the BO and intended for local delivery.
- **Registered Newspapers:** The office of posting is responsible for correct postage. The office of delivery should generally not challenge this unless negligence is suspected, in which case a report is made to the Superintendent.

Chapter 7: Registration and Insurance

Rule 77. Registered Journal (RP-51)

- **Usage:** Records receipts given to senders of ordinary registered articles (excluding V.P. and insured).
- **Numbering:** Contains **200 receipts** with printed serial numbers running from **1 to 200**.

Rule 79. Registered and Parcel Lists

- **Registered List:** Form RP-32.
- **Parcel List:** Form RP-3.
- **Corrections:** Corrections to entry numbers or office of posting must be initialed by the BPM.

- **Prohibition:** No **correction** is allowed in the *total* of the entries. If the total is incorrect, the list must be destroyed and a fresh one prepared.

Rule 80. Acknowledgement

Registered articles addressed to a foreign country requiring an acknowledgement must be clearly marked with "**Avis de reception**".

Rule 85. Registered Articles Found in Letter Box

- **Procedure:** If an inland article marked "Registered" is found in the letter box, it must be registered immediately.
- **Penalty:** If not fully prepaid, charge a fee equal to **double** the usual registration fee plus the postage due.

Rule 93. Conditions of Insurance

Registered letters and parcels (including V.P.) may be insured at a Branch Office up to the value of Rs. 600 for authorized offices.

 **LEGISLATIVE NOTE:** The limit of **Rs. 600** is the standard text provided in Manual Vol VI Part III for Branch Offices. However, monetary limits for various services are subject to periodic revision by the Directorate.

Rule 94. Treatment of Insured Articles

- **Reference:** Consult the *Post Office Guide Volume III* to verify if the destination office accepts insured articles (ensure no symbol "B" or "L" indicates restriction).
- **Fees:** Acknowledgements for inland insured letters (**RP-54**) are free. Foreign insured letters require a special fee if acknowledgement is requested.

Chapter 8: Accounts and Remittances

Rule 124. Branch Office Account (PA-6)

- **Definition:** Records monetary transactions between the BO and the Account Office.
- **Exclusions:** Cash realized from postage collections must **never** be included in "Cash collected".
- **V.P. Articles:** Amounts collected for V.P. articles delivered are credited under "Money orders issued".
- **Reply Coupons:** Value of stamps exchanged for reply-coupons is shown under "Unclassified payments".

Chapter 8: Accounts and Remittances

Rule 129. Monthly Abstract in B.O. Bag

The Branch Office (B.O.) bag closed on the **1st of each month** must contain the **Abstract of Monetary Transactions** for the entire preceding month. This abstract is to be submitted in **Form PA-7**.

Chapter 9: Account Office Documentation

This section outlines the specific documents prepared by the Account Office (A.O.) regarding Branch Office operations. These forms are critical for the reconciliation of accounts between the B.O. and the A.O.

- **B.O. Slip (PA-4):** This document serves as the primary communication and accounting slip sent from the Account Office to the Branch Office.
 - **B.O. Summary (ACG-3(a)):** A summary document prepared at the Account Office to consolidate and record the daily transactions of the Branch Office.
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Rule 130. Remittances Sent Through Post

- **Bag Types:**
 - **Cloth Bags:** Used for remittances of currency notes only, up to Rs. 500.
 - **Leather Cash Bags:** Used for remittances including coins or exceeding Rs. 500.

Rule 134. Preparation of BO Daily Account

- **Process:** Entries from the BO Account are copied into the BO Daily Account (ACG-22(a)).
- **Nil Transactions:** On days with no monetary transaction, submit the account in form ACG-22(c) instead of ACG-22(a).

Appendix A: Master Schedule of Prescribed Forms

For ease of reference, the following table consolidates all statutory forms and registers mentioned throughout the *Book of B.O. Rules*.

Form No.	Title / Description	Purpose
M-6(c)	Notice of Hours of Business	To be displayed publicly in the office.
M-52	Village Sorting List	Lists villages served by ABPM and letter box locations.
M-53	Route List	Details the route, schedule, and halts for the ABPM.

MS-2	Error Book	Records all irregularities and errors noticed.
MS-6	Half-yearly Enumeration Return	Statistics on unregistered articles (Feb & Aug).
MS-8	Order Book	For remarks and orders by inspecting officers.
MS-10	Check Slip	Label tied to labeled bundles (Pink/White/Blue).
MS-18	Book of Postmarks	Daily record of stamp and seal impressions.
MS-27	Postman Book	Record of articles/cash given to Postman.
MS-85	Village Postman Register	Register for Village Postman transactions.
MS-86	Village Postman Visit Book	Record of village visits (Red/Black ink entries).
MS-87(a)	Book of Receipts	Receipts for registered/insured articles, MOs, PLI.
MS-88	Yearly Village Return	Statistics on articles received for villages (March).
MS-94	Complaint/Suggestion Book	Public record for grievances and suggestions.

PA-4	B.O. Slip	Accounting slip from Account Office to BO.
PA-5	B.O. Journal	Daily record of B.O. transactions.
PA-6	B.O. Account	Monetary transaction record between BO and AO.
PA-7	Monthly Abstract	Abstract of monetary transactions sent on the 1st.
ACG-3(a)	B.O. Summary	Prepared at AO to summarize BO accounts.
ACG-22(a)	B.O. Daily Account	Daily submission of accounts to AO.
ACG-22(c)	B.O. Daily Account (Nil)	Submitted when there are <i>no</i> monetary transactions.
RP-3	Parcel List	List of parcels dispatched.
RP-32	Registered List	List of registered articles dispatched.
RP-51	Registered Journal	Receipts for ordinary registered articles.
RP-54	Acknowledgement	For inland registered/insured articles.
App-45	Leave Application	Application form for GDS/ABPM leave.

Appendix B: Legislative Note on Monetary Limits

⚠ IMPORTANT COMPLIANCE NOTE

The monetary limits mentioned in the notes reflect the baseline figures from the Book of BO Rules. However, these limits are frequently revised by Directorate Orders. Staff must verify the currently applicable limits with their Divisional Office.

1. **Cash Remittance (Rule 130):** The text mentions a limit of Rs. 500 for cloth bags and specific use of leather bags for higher amounts.
 - *Current Status:* Cash conveyance limits have been significantly enhanced. Modern protocols often allow higher limits (e.g., Rs. 5 Lakhs or more) subject to specific security arrangements (police escort, special carrier, etc.). The distinction between cloth and leather bags now depends largely on the mode of conveyance and local Circle orders.
2. **Insurance Limit (Rule 93):** The text states a limit of Rs. 600 for Branch Offices.
 - *Current Status:* While Rs. 600 is the traditional limit for independent BO booking, many Branch Offices are now authorized to book insured articles up to higher values (e.g., **Rs. 100,000** for V.P. or Insurance) depending on their classification and account status (e.g., if running on RICT/DARPAN devices).
3. **Article Weight (Rule 9):** The text specifies a weight limit of **10 kg** for delivery staff.
 - *Current Status:* This adheres to the standard manual labor limits, but specific restrictions apply for parcels delivered by foot versus those delivered by bicycle or other conveyance.